To See You Bleed

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32476417.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Other

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Canon Universe, Alternate Canon, TW: animal cruelty, Threats of Rape/Non-Con, Graphic Violence, Trans Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Suicidal Thoughts, Suicide Attempt, Past Child Abuse, Childhood Sexual Abuse

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by Arceanedes

Summary

Catran lives in a cruel world of abuse, neglect, and violence. As a child in the Horde, he is expected to grow up to kill and destroy, efficiently and without mercy, and he has learned those lessons well. He's also learned that even the people who are supposed to be on his side can't be trusted. The adult who raised him tortured him with her magic, the team he grows up with don't respect him. In the brutal world of the Horde, Catran grows up without friends or protection. Every day is a fight.

The only bright spot in his life is Adora, his lifelong companion. She's the only person he's ever trusted, the only person who seems to care.

On top of that, Catran hasn't been feeling all that comfortable in his body, lately. It has its advantages, sure, but sometimes... sometimes it just doesn't fit. And there isn't a single person he can talk to about that. Even Adora might not understand.

When Adora leaves the Horde and joins the enemy, Catran's entire world collapses. But he's been fighting his entire life. He isn't going to give up now.

(It's She-Ra Season One told from the POV of non-binary Catra.)

Notes

The conceit of this story is a non-binary Catra who is assigned male at birth. We don't into that much in Book One, but I wanted to let you know upfront that I'm keeping She-Ra queer. Adora is a lesbian. No. Question.

See the end of the work for more notes

Cover For Me

Chapter Summary

In which Catran is left in the worst place on Etheria.

Chapter Notes

The Fright Zone is a truly awful place. Don't judge too harshly.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catran is afraid. The fear sits with him like a bad meal, resting uncomfortably in his belly. It's familiar, this ache. He's felt it as long as he can remember, and it makes him vulnerable in ways that he hates.

But it's there. All the time. Rotting his guts out.

Today they have another room. The rooms are boring. Same sequences, same tired old bots, same stupid squad. Same stupid Adora, trying to do everything right, do everything by the rules. She never understands how badly designed all the training exercises are, how you can just slip past all their defenses and get to the end with almost no effort. She says she knows. "That's not the point, Catran. They're supposed to teach us about tactics."

Catran doesn't know much about tactics, outside of his training, but he suspects that real enemies aren't very predictable. His mostly aren't. Adora wouldn't know that... she doesn't have any enemies. None that Catran hasn't quietly and viciously dealt with, anyway. Catran has nothing but enemies.

And Adora.

One time, a couple of weeks ago, he heard two cadets talking about Adora. About what they wanted to do to Adora, how she was high and mighty and needed to be taken down a peg. They

were talking quietly, of course, because people had learned that Shadow Weaver didn't *like* that kind of talk, and when Shadow Weaver didn't *like* something, she could make that painfully and even terminally clear.

So these boys... they were being quiet. "We could get her behind the foundry," One had said. "Show her a good time. Teach her to keep her mouth shut."

"Or open." The other had said, and they had both laughed nastily to themselves.

Catran didn't know exactly what they were saying. He wasn't sure, really, what they were implying. But the laughs were ugly, and he had felt a tiny, small ball of rage build up inside him.

He got one boy from behind when the two split up a little later. Two quick swipes and his left leg was useless, hamstring, achilles. Snick. Snick. Then a quick slash across the face. Left the eye, though. Shadow Weaver did not like it when he blinded people. She had made that painfully clear. Almostly terminally clear.

The other came running when the first started screaming, but Catran was already hidden when he showed up. He was big, much bigger than the first boy but still human. Soft. Weak. Slow. They were all soft and weak. When Catran hit him from behind, he tore holes in his shoulders with his hands and dug his feet into his kidneys. Catran knows where all the soft spots are, he has taken apart more tiny furry creatures than he can count, learning how living things die.

He left them bleeding on the ground. He cleaned himself up and went back to the barracks. He curled up, purring, at Adora's feet until Shadow Weaver came to have a little conversation about the evening’s events.

It had been worth it, absolutely worth it.

That’s tactics. Attack quickly and unexpectedly. Give no quarter. Expect no quarter. Be willing to take the consequences.

Adora never understands that, but that’s okay. She has Catran to understand it for her. But she is just so slow. Catran has been waiting almost five minutes for her to get through the stupid room to kill the "princess" bot at the end.

She finally shows up, fights the "right way" and avoids the traps like a good girl, until Catran decides to show himself and take the bot down for good. It's great when she falls into the last trap, just classic Adora. She catches herself, too, because while Adora is human, she is faster and stronger than any human he knows and she is really good at adapting when she stops trying to plan.

He looks down at her. She is holding onto her staff with one hand, perfectly calm, those beautiful eyes looking up at him with frustration and grudging respect.

"Hey Adora, how's it hanging?"

Stupid Adora has a Captain’s Badge.

Catran sits on a rooftop, high above the Fright Zone. The fear isn't as bad up here. No one can follow him. No one even knows all the high places he goes. Not even Adora. She knows this one, though. He wants her to find him. If she doesn't, he'll go to a place that's a little easier for her to get to, but he hopes she'll make the effort to find him here, so he can pretend he doesn't care that she did.

She pretends she doesn't notice too. That's what makes her special. She sees how afraid he is but she pretends she doesn't. She knows how much he needs her, but she doesn't hold it over him. She's different, even if she is an idiot. Even if she never really understands... everything.

He shouldn't care. He doesn't even want to be a Force Captain. He just doesn't want to be left behind. If he can't go with her, who will protect her? If something happens to her, who will protect *him* ? How can they watch out for each other if she's out on an

operation and he's stuck running through stupid predictable rooms set up by stupid predictable people?

Sometimes he thinks that the enemy might not be very strong. Because their training is pretty pathetic, but they win battles. At least, soldiers go out, soldiers come back boasting about how they fought so and so many princesses and barely escaped with their lives.

Shadow Weaver is a liar. Hordak is clearly just a big bully. There's more to it than they're being told, certainly. Maybe there isn't even a war, and they're fighting their own bots. Who even knows?

And where *is* Adora, anyway? She usually doesn't take so long to find him, not if he's really upset, not if she knows where he is. Maybe he isn't worth the climb today. Maybe today is the day that she realizes that she doesn't really want him around after all.

Not now that she's a Force Captain.

And she'll be moving to the Force Captain's barracks. He'll be alone.

The fear sits like a rock in his stomach, dragging his lungs flat. She's gone.

Then he hears the grappling hook, and has to suppress a purr. She's found him. She'll always find him. Everything is going to be okay.

It had been a pretty good day, maybe even the best day.

Catran had never been outside the Fright Zone. Never. It was so different. The first thing was the smell. In the Fright Zone, the smells almost hurt. They are sharp and acrid and overpowering. Metal, and smoke, and *burning* metal. No matter how far he gets from the foundry he can smell it, on his clothes, in his fur. Even on Adora, unless she has just worked out or is just stepping out of the shower.

Out in the whispering woods... he doesn't have the words for the smells but they were intoxicating. They were... maybe it was like how people described colors. Catran didn't really see colors very well. Adora had said once that a sunset was beautiful, and she had tried to describe it to him, how she could see all these different shades in what to him was just a flat sky of reddish-brown. In the woods, he could smell so many things that he couldn't even count them all, much less identify them. Some were animals, he was sure, but others were sweeter, or heavier, or darker, or... he just didn't have the words. But maybe it was like a sunset.

He could have stayed out there forever, just sitting in a tree and breathing in.

Stupid Adora would get in trouble, though, if he did that. Shadow Weaver would find them. She always knows where they are, no matter how much they try to hide. Always. So she would have found them in the woods, so Catran went back to the Fright Zone with Adora. It’s where they belong, anyway. That bright, intoxicating world isn’t for them.

Still. It had been a good day.

Until now. Catran lies curled up on Adora's bed, face buried in her pillow, filling his lungs with the particular smell of Adora asleep.

"Cover for me," she’d said, and he’d just stood there. Why did he let her leave without him? Why did he stay when she told him to? He shivered, wanting to get up and follow her. It would be easy enough, he could steal a skiff and head to the woods and just follow his nose. Even in the incredible sensory overload of the woods he would be able to find Adora, he was sure.

If he is spotted missing, and comes back, he’ll get in trouble. Adora won’t. But he’ll probably get in trouble anyway. Shadow Weaver will find a way to blame him for this. Maybe he should run away. Maybe he can find Adora and they can both run away.

But what if he can't find her? Then they'll both be lost.

The fear clamps onto his gut and he whimpers, burying his head even harder to stifle the sound. Finally he burrows under the covers, so that the smell of Adora is everywhere, and lies shivering until dawn.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter Two is written and just needs editing.

Your comments, criticisms, and curses are welcome.

One Night

Chapter Summary

In which Catran realizes that Adora is gone, and he's going to suffer for it.

Chapter Notes

This chapter contains torture, violence, and shame.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catran is being tortured again. This is not unusual. Practically routine. He tries to get used to it, tries to get used to pain when he's not around Shadow Weaver. But the worst things he can do to himself just aren't the same.

Shadow Weaver's pain radiates out from his bones. It burns and freezes and it feels like his own body is tearing itself apart from the inside, like his guts are melting. He's helpless when she holds him in her magic like this, and she's done it so many times that he feels weak for not being able to handle it but it still just hurts.

Although, she's got control. He'll give her that. She, like him, has learned how much pain and damage little creatures can take. He'll be able to breathe and walk normally when she lets him go. This is just a little warning. A way to let him know how bad things can be. As if he needed it.

"Your insolence will not protect her. You will do as I ask." Her voice is soft, almost affectionate. It's the same game she's always plays with him. *I don't want to hurt you, Catran. Why do you make me hurt you?* His fault. Always his fault. He summons as much defiance as he can.

"Oh yeah? Or what?"

"Or you will suffer the consequences in her place." And *there* was the nasty voice. The uncloaked threat. Finally. The consequences. He does not want to suffer more consequences. Shadow Weaver is very, very good at consequences.

A couple of times, Shadow Weaver has locked his muscles up so much that when she let go he wet himself. That was bad. Once she even made him jizz. That was worse.

That had been the first time that had *ever* happened to him. He couldn't understand why anyone would want to feel something that hurt so much it made you black out and wake up with your pants ruined. It was disgusting, which is what Shadow Weaver said. *You are a filthy creature. You're only alive because Adora can't see how disgusting you are.* He'd managed to skulk back to the barracks without anyone seeing.

He had heard some things from other cadets, of course. Not that they talked to him, but Catran could hear people talking from a very long way away indeed and so had picked up a thing or two. Like, the word jizz. It was supposed to feel good. He just didn’t understand why it had to be so gross.

And he had his own experiences, now. One of the hardest things he had had to train himself not to do was to have wet dreams. He had learned to wake up, dragging himself painfully out of sleep and *focusing* , quieting his breathing, hoping he hadn't woken Adora up.

By then their sleeping arrangements had altered a bit. They didn't cuddle under the covers like they had when he was little. He would go to bed in his bunk and end up at the foot of her bed, and she wouldn't comment on that. It was a good arrangement.

One that was worth trying to get back. Even if Adora *had* set him up for this.

Besides, it's not like Shadow Weaver ever hurt Adora. So she wouldn't face any consequences for this at all. Mabye Shadow

Weaver would even be pleased.

It would be better if he could get her back. Then everything would be okay again.

Catran doesn't understand why he didn't just disembowel the boy with the bow and arrows. He could have, easily. Swipe, swipe, no more intestines. Messy, but not difficult.

But he didn't do it. He doesn't know why. He hasn't killed a person before, but he didn't even *hurt* the boy. It's confusing. They were trying to protect Adora. From him.

How did that even make sense?

He had thought she would be happy to see him. Eager to come with him. Ready to be rescued. But she hadn't been, at all. She was upset that he was there. He could tell that from the way she said his name, the way she looked at him.

"How could you possibly be okay with that?"

That didn't even make sense. How could he be okay with their life, the life they had been raised for? Because she had been okay with it! She had told him time and time again how they would rise through the Horde together and then everything would be okay. They would win the war, and bring peace to Etheria, and they would be free to do whatever they wanted.

Together.

"I'm not going home, Catran."

It had finally happened. She was done. She had used as much of him as she could, and now she was done. She was going to leave, and maybe get the girlfriend she always wanted. She couldn't *wait* to get rid of him. It was so obvious. Nothing he had ever done had been enough for her. She would never love him.

Not like he loved her.

"Come with me!"

And what... be her... pet? Follow her into... into who knows what just because she didn't want to be in The Horde anymore? What else would they even be if not Horde soldiers? How would that even happen? Take second place to... whatever people had taken her away? For a moment he considered it. Would it be enough? Could it be enough? Maybe there was a path to happiness for them, if they just stayed together.

But he could hear Shadow Weaver as well, *"Or you will suffer the consequences."*

The anger came then. Of *course* Adora was willing to change sides. Of *course* Adora thought it was okay to just walk away. She wouldn't suffer the consequences. Catran would. Like he always did.

So he hit her with the shock stick. He had hit Adora before, of course, in training, but this was different. They had never fought for real. But he hit her with the stick, and she crumpled to the ground and for one sickening moment he thought she was dead.

But then her *new* friends had shown up, and Catran was wrapped up in a net and then Adora was gone.

And now she's a *Princess.* In one night. He let her out of his sight for *one night* and she was gone, like he had never existed.

He should have torn that boy apart.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry to post this one so late, I've been traveling for the last 20 hours.

Promotion

Chapter Summary

Catran finally gets some recognition.

Chapter Notes

Content warnings for violence and death.

Catran hates Lonnie so much.

She's stupid, and blind, and... and stupid. Adora *never* protected Catran. Catran protected Adora, and Adora never even saw what happened when he did.

But she's right. Adora *is* gone. She isn't here to take care of him any more. And maybe she'll never come back. He won't betray her, though. He won't tell that she's a princess now.

She's not in the bed they've shared for as long as he can remember. Not in the barracks. Not in the Fright Zone at all. She's gone. But maybe she'll come back. Whether she comes back or not, Lonnie is going to regret telling him to be careful.

Lonnie has it backwards. Adora hasn't been protecting him from Lonnie. She's been protecting Lonnie from him. Lonnie has no idea how slow and weak she really is. Because she's stupid. They're all stupid.

He doesn't want to hurt Lonnie. Not really. He wishes he could want to be friends with her, but he can't. He's never really been able to tolerate sharing Adora with anyone, and Lonnie... well. He's jealous of Lonnie.

He used to watch Adora look at Lonnie, sometimes. He could see how Adora looked at the lines of Lonnie's muscles, the smooth curve of her hips. He wants to be someone Adora could look at like that. Someone she could want. But that's a weak thought.

He has to be strong. Now that he's alone and Adora is gone.

He sits in their bunk and stares at the scratched drawing of the two of them that he made years ago. The sheer weight of her absence crashes down on him and for a moment he can't breathe. The fear that sits in his belly rises up and tears a hole in his chest and it hurts more than he has ever thought it was possible for something to hurt.

Catran tears the bed apart and sobs. She left him. She never loved him.

But that doesn't feel true either.

He tries to remember that Adora doesn't know everything. That she doesn't know what Shadow Weaver does to him when she's not around. She can't know what it feels like to have that power unleashed on you. Adora has never faced the consequences. It’s just one of many things about life in the Fright Zone that Adora has been protected from.

It's hard to remember that without hating her. It's the only thing he can focus on to *keep* from hating her.

Catran forces himself to stop. He focuses on just breathing, slowing down, examining his tactical situation. It could be worse. No one knows how wounded he is. No one knows how much this hurts him. No one knows how weak he is.

And now Shadow Weaver is here. It's time to face the *consequences* .

Catran is alone in the Captain’s Barracks. He should be happy. He's a Force Captain. Hordak shut Shadow Weaver down right in front of him. That felt good, but now it doesn't feel good anymore. Hordak is just one more person to be scared of. The tactics never change. Shadow Weaver tries to make him look weak to other people, to keep him scared, and now Hordak is doing that to Shadow Weaver. So Hordak will do that to him, if he

gets the chance. If he's in charge, that just means that he'll be watched even more closely. It's power, but it's weakness too.

One thing, he doesn't have to worry about Lonnie knowing he's the boss anymore, does he? She knows. She won't ever think that he's hiding behind Adora again. She should know better already, but she's stupid, like they're all stupid, and she can only see the glow around Adora and follow her around.

Well now he can give orders, and she has to do what he says. And he can definitely use that to hurt her, in ways that Adora can't complain about even if she *does* come back.

He wants her to come back. It hurts so much, being alone in this room, in the Captain’s Barracks. His own room. He's never slept alone before. This bed doesn't smell like Adora. It smells like stale lizard sweat.

He thinks about going back to his old barracks and stealing some of Adora's things. Maybe a shirt, he could wrap that around his pillow and she'd still be there to help him sleep.

When they were little, Adora would always find him when he was scared. She spent hours hunting for every hiding place he had. She would find him, and hold him, and scratch behind his ears and comb his mane until he purred and purred. Adora's arms were the only safe place in the whole Fright Zone, and even if the cuddling had stopped as they grew up, she would still pet his mane or scratch lazily behind his ears. She said the purring helped her sleep too.

Catran wonders how Adora is sleeping. In *her* new room, wherever it is, with her new friends . Whoever they are, he hates them.

Catran goes hunting. There has to be something in the Fright Zone that he can kill without getting in trouble.

The fauntling sees the approaching tank and freezes. The stuffed toy in their arms falls to the ground and their eyes seem to meet Catran's for a moment, before he presses the trigger with his foot and the tank's main gun fires. Then they're gone, and the building behind them is just burning rubble.

Then the building rebuilds itself, the toy rises from the ground and back into the child's arms. The child looks away from the tank. Then they see the tank, and freeze, and Catran kills them again. Then the building rebuilds itself and the toy lifts up and it falls and Catran kills them *again* .

And again.

Catran wakes up in his own bunk, stifling a scream. He's panting, and his fur is wet around his eyes. He hugs himself in the dark, claws digging into his arms. It was just a dream. It hadn't really happened. He didn't incinerate a child.

Or... maybe he did. That's the thing about Horde equipment. It doesn't show the real world, it shows a projection over everything. Everything is a soldier through the viewer. A badly superimposed soldier, but a soldier. Through the viewer, the real world looks a lot like a training room.

It's supposed to be a tactical display. It's a lie. Like everything in his life. Like himself.

He was having fun, with the tank. When he got out of the tank, he could smell the burning buildings. He could smell burning flesh. He could smell death. He was focused on Adora, at the time, but now he can remember.

"How can you be okay with this?"

Is he okay with this? Does it matter? It's done. He's done it, and he's going to have to keep doing it if he wants to live. It's not like the Princesses are perfectly innocent. It's not like they couldn't end the war if they wanted to. They want to hold on to their power as much as Hordak wants to take it.

Catran licks the blood from his claws, then cleans his ears, grooms his fur. He catches himself grooming past the point of usefulness and forces himself to stop.

Adora had helped him with that. When he was younger, she had noticed a raw patch on his arm, where he had licked away the fur. She had cried when she saw the sore. She didn't say anything at first, she just found a medkit, and applied a clumsy bandage. When she was done, she sat next to him.

"Why is your arm sore?"

Her eyes, always so soft when she looked at him, had still been shiny with tears. He couldn't answer. He was ashamed. It was just so comforting, and he was so scared. She wouldn't understand.

"Catran?"

He had just looked away.

She had snuggled up to him, though.

"It's okay. I get scared too."

She did understand. Catran had relaxed into her for just a moment, then poked her in the belly to start another game.

He hasn't felt the need in a long time. He won't now. When she comes back, he doesn't want her to see him like that.

He sits and stares at the wall until the lights come up.

Shadows

Chapter Summary

Catran finds another thing to be afraid of.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Just cover for me, okay?"

She had asked. So he is. He doesn't know why he's still covering for her, covering up for her being a Princess now. It's stupid. When she comes back, he's not going to let her forget how embarrassing this would be for her if he told people she had turned into a Princess. He's looking forward to it.

If she comes back.

He can't even think about what happens if she doesn't come back. She's going to come back, and they're both going to be Force Captains, and then they'll be able to bunk together again. He won't be alone anymore, and things will be even better than they were before. They'll rise up through the Horde and take over like they always said they would and then they'll finally be able to do something else.

He doesn't know what that would look like. What else would they do? But it sounds nice, the idea of just being alone with Adora in a place... in a place that smells like the Whispering Woods. A place where the air doesn't sear his nostrils, where he doesn't have to be so afraid all the time. A place where he belongs.

He shakes his head. That's stupid. They'll never get to that place. And he isn't sure that Adora ever wanted to anyway. She doesn't need him anymore.

Now that she's a Princess.

In the dream, Catran feels different.

He isn't sure how, at first, but his body *fits*, in a way it hasn't since he was a child. His movement is always fluid, but this feels different somehow. Free.

He tries to figure it out, but in the way of dreams, he can't really see himself. He can see his hands, but somehow he can't get his eyes focused on anything else. It's odd, but it doesn't really concern him. It feels natural. Everything feels fine.

He turns his attention to his surroundings and realizes that he's in the Whispering Woods. It's a beautiful, warm day. He wanders through the trees, enjoying the sunlight. He can feel the soft earth under his feet, even if he can't *see* his feet.

After what feels like a long time, he comes to a clearing. There's a mirror hanging on a tree, so he walks towards it.

The face in the mirror is his face, but it's not. The jaw is thinner, the features just a touch softer. He puts a hand to the tufts by his ears. The fur isn't quite as coarse as his own.

Oh, he thinks. *There I am.*

Shadow Weaver is in the shadows.

She is in the actual shadows.

She can watch him from the actual *shadows.*

Catran stares around his quarters. If there's light, there are shadows. If there's no light, are there no shadows? Or is everything a shadow? It doesn't matter, because there's always light, now that he thinks of it. The faint lights over the door are always on. Now that he thinks about it, Horde soldiers are almost never in the dark, not really. There's always some light, enough to see by.

Enough for Shadow Weaver to hide in.

Catran has always found comfort in shadows. He could hide from the other cadets in them until Adora came for him. That comfort is gone now. The shadows are contaminated with *her.*

Part of him hopes that Adora doesn't come back. He's never really thought about *why* Shadow Weaver is the way she is with Adora. It's just been a fact of life. Adora is the favorite. She's Shadow Weaver's favorite, she's Catran's favorite. Most of the younger cadets love her.

But this is something else. He thinks about Shadow Weaver spying on them from the shadows. Sitting in Adora's shadow. Can she *hear* what's happening, or just see it? How many times has she watched Adora sleep, or eat, or shower? He has a sense of profound wrongness. It feels creepy. It's a feeling he recognizes, a feeling he's tried to protect Adora from for their whole lives. How can he protect her from shadows?

He never thought he would have to protect Adora from Shadow Weaver.

How would you know that one of them was there? There are shadows that don't move, under his bed, behind a table, *everywhere.* All the time. He can't hide under his covers. He can't hide anywhere. Anywhere he can hide, Shadow Weaver can get there first.

Chapter End Notes

I've had that dream.

Mad as a Wet Cat

Chapter Summary

Catran confronts Adora at the Sea Gate

Catran is not happy to be on this boat. He is not happy to be heading out into the ocean. He is definitely not happy to be paired up with the gigantic baby sitter with *no* sense of personal space. If Shadow Weaver had not been there when Scorpia picked him up, he would have ripped her ears to ribbons.

But now, for some reason, she is *always* talking to him. Always near him. Always trying to engage him. He hates it. It reminds him of Adora, but this version of Adora has absolutely no sense of what he needs or when he needs it. On the other hand, this version of Adora isn't Shadow Weaver's pet, so maybe he can work with that.

There was a time he thought they could use Shadow Weaver's obsession with Adora to their advantage. They could have been strong together, happy, even.

Hadn't they been happy? He remembers being happy, sometimes, when the two of them could get away from everyone else. The knot in his chest only loosened when it was just the two of them. Sometimes, it even vanished altogether.

Adora should be in this boat, leading this mission. He shouldn't be here with this blabbering giant. Everything is wrong.

When he and Adora were children, they had planned on running away. Then they got older, and the plan changed. Catran had been having consequences time with Shadow Weaver, and Adora had been waiting on their bunk when he came back to the barracks. She hadn't said a word, just gotten up, grabbed his hand, and taken him to the base on one of *their* climbs, to one of *their* places.

Adora dropped his hand and stepped back, flinging a grappling hook upwards with practiced ease. He heard it catch on a pipe, saw her give a couple of quick tugs, and then she was walking up the wall, the soft soles of her boots easily gripping the rough metal, strong arms easily handling her weight.

Catran stood listening, staring at the wall. He was so tired. Every muscle in his body ached. The after effects of Shadow Weavers magic were never pleasant, but this time she had hit something that was leaving him shaking and confused, uncertain as to why she had summoned him the first place.

Adora made it to the first platform and started her climb to a second, by hand this time. He could hear the small slaps her hands made as she gripped pipes and seams, the quick exhales as she swung and levered her way across the wall. She was so pathetically slow to make this climb. He couldn't remember if he had ever been the one on the ground before. Had he ever followed her to a high place? Or had he always waited for her to follow him?

Adora stopped at another wide ledge and tossed the hook up again. Her breath was a bit more labored now. This was hard for her, harder than he had really realized. He felt something in the fur of his cheek and raised a hand to touch his face. It was wet. Was he crying? Adora was high enough now to go to an old landing pad that looked out over the fright zone. But she didn't. She kept climbing, towards the roof. That was probably the highest spot in the Fright Zone, one they didn't go to much. From there, they could look out, away from the Fright Zone. They couldn't see what was out there, but they could imagine. Imagine a world that was about something other than pain.

Adora's world wasn't just about pain though. That was Catran's world. The world he hated Adora for not seeing, and the world he loved her for not being.

Eventually, he had followed, scaling the wall in five easy, lazy jumps. Adora was sitting with her back to him, legs dangling over

the edge, staring out into the filthy haze. Catran slipped easily into place beside her. He rubbed a cheek against her shoulder and she absentmindedly reached up to scratch his ear.

"Hey Adora."

She smiled, still looking far away.

"I've been thinking," she sighed. "That we need a plan to end this war and get free of Shadow Weaver. To get free of Hordak. Not just us, Catran. Everybody."

That had been Adora at fourteen. What had happened in the last four years, Catran wonders, his stomach churning with the awful motion of the boat, to make her forget that?

Adora is so *stupid* . Why is she doing this? Is it because of that purply sparkly girl? Is that it? Has Adora finally found a girl she actually wants and it's... *that* girl?

The thought makes Catran vaguely sick. It's not like Adora ever has been, ever could be, interested in him like that. It's awful and he hates it, but he doesn't take it personally. It's just... *that* girl? He could see her being interested in... well, he's not sure. Adora hasn't really had crushes, exactly, at least not that she's told him. She likes muscles, so maybe someone like Scorpia? But *that* girl? That... purple, fluffy, sparkly girl?

He doesn't like that idea *at all.* It feels like betrayal in a way... because *his* Adora wouldn't have been interested in someone like that. His Adora also wasn't an eight-foot tall Princess, one so strong that when Catran balanced on her sword the stupid thing didn't even dip. Catran isn't big, he's actually a little smaller than even normal-sized Adora, but still.

How do you beat someone like that? Probably a good start would be taking the sword. Then it would just be Catran against Adora, and he knows he can win that fight.

It's a half day walk back into Horde territory from where they wash up to shore, and Scorpia *literally* talks the entire way. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle sort of keep to themselves, but Scorpia is just... she just talks. All the time. About nothing. How can she be so positive after they just failed in their mission?

And why is she even talking to Catran in the first place? What does she want?

That's an interesting question. She wants something. So how can he keep her wanting it?

Interlude

Chapter Summary

Catran has a moment to themself.

Chapter Notes

As always, check the tags for warnings.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catran is furious.

At first, he thought that maybe Adora was just going through some kind of weird phase. That she would get over this stupidity and just come back to the Fright Zone, back to *him*, back where she belonged.

Captains don't share a locker room with one or two other barracks. Catran actually shares a bathroom with a single other room with a door on either side that, naturally, doesn't lock. Catran opens it, to find the other room abandoned. The furniture is there, but it's clear that no one lives there, that no one *has* lived there for a long time. A lot of the Fright Zone is empty. The Horde doesn't seem to be putting much effort into recruitment, prefering bots to soldiers. Every once in a while new children are brought in by some raiding party or another, but for the most part the Horde doesn't grow like it used to.

Or so he assumes. He doesn't know very much about the history of the war. It's just always been there, with the horrible enemy on the other side and the constant need to train and fight. They never really talk about what happened last year. For his whole life, they've been "making progress" in winning against the Princesses. Until Thaymor, Catran wasn't even sure that these "Princesses" really existed.

Now Adora is one, might be... well, sleeping with one.

He curls his claws into the doorframe. That... that is *their* thing. Adora is *his. She isn't,* he thinks. *She can't be.*

He hates that voice. The voice that tells him that none of this would be happening if he just weren't a boy. If he could have been what Adora wanted, what he wanted to be for her. *And what's that?*

Not me, *that's what. I'll never be right.*

He feels a surge of rage at that thought. *It isn't* fair. *I was* born *in this body, it's not like I* chose *it, I don't even* like *it.* Which maybe isn't strictly true, he does like his body, he likes the speed and the power and the grace, but *he could have all those things and* Adora *if only...*

Stupid. Stupid Adora. Stupid, weak, Catran. Stupid, stupid body, stupid fright zone, stupid Shadow Weaver, it isn't *fair*, it isn't *right,* it isn't *his fault*, it's never *been* his fault...

He's sobbing now, and he's torn the metal frame of the bed and the desk into shreds. There's nothing left to destroy, so he stands, staring at his claws, wondering, not for the first time, whether he could just tear his own throat out and get it over with. It probably wouldn't even be that hard to do.

He raises a hand to his neck and presses the tips of his fingers against the arteries and veins. He can feel that he has it right. All he would need to do is just... extend. That's all. Just...

"Uh, Catran?" A voice calls from the other room. It's Scorpia. Of *course* it's Scorpia. "Are you in here?"

He steps into the bathroom and closes the door behind him, wiping his eyes and trying to look... well, less like a crazy person who just tore apart a room.

"Wow, Scorpia. Can't a guy use the bathroom in peace around here?"

"Sorry, sorry!" He can *hear* her cringing. How someone so strong can be so beaten down is beyond him. "But Shadow Weaver sent me to find you. She wants you in the Black Garnett chamber?"

"Sure. Fine. Tell her I'll be right there."

"Oh! Um... okay, just, the thing is that she seems really interested in seeing you right away and..."

"Okay! Fine! I'm done in here anyway."

He steps out of the bathroom. Scorpia is hovering in the door of his room, looking nervous and upset. She sees him and her eyes go wide. They drop from his face to his claws and she even winces. What the hell is her problem?

"Um... Catran?"

"What *now*, Scorpia?"

"You're um... you're... bleeding."

He touches his neck. His fingers come away stained with blood.

"Yeah. I am. It'll stop. Why are we still standing here?"

She turns and heads off toward the Black Garnett chamber. Catran walks behind, meticulously cleaning the blood from his claws.

Chapter End Notes

> It's always dangerous to make up stories about how other people see you.
>
> This is my favorite chapter so far, after chapter one. I know that Catran's dysphoria is kind of a slow burn, but I've got plans and those plans extend past this book and into the next couple. We'll get there.
>
> One thing I worry about is the balance between cause and effect. I don't want to give the impression that the fact of

their gender identity is the root of their self destructive tendencies, and I hope I'm not doing that. What I want to get across is that Catran's problem, their real problem, is abuse. Abuse by Shadow Weaver, abuse by their environment. It's being stuck in a world in which there's no room to process, no time to not be on alert, no chance to just sit down and be vulnerable.

Catran lives in a world where maiming two of their fellow cadets leads to consequences, but those consequences aren't any worse than what happens if they mouth off to Shadow Weaver.

I don't think young trans people in the United States live in that kind of world. But I do think that people who are different live their lives on high alert. I know I did, and it was hard. I lashed out at weird times because I felt threatened. In some ways, it made me cruel. I could have ended up being a troll, being someone blind to the pain of others. I didn't, I think partly because I was able to find a clique of people that wasn't just straight boys, but had girls and gay boys and, well, me. I think that rescued me from being some kind of gamergate asswipe. Being with people who expressed love mattered. Being (mostly) myself with people who expressed love mattered.

This is the story of someone whose whole life has been lived on high alert, constantly scared, constantly on shifting ground, trying to generate enough leverage to feel safe. That someone is non-binary, but that's not the most important thing about them. The most important thing about them is that the only person who expressed love to them, who they trusted enough to express love for, left them to fight alone.

Guard Duty

Chapter Summary

> There's nothing like watching Shadow Weaver's back to make you wonder about stabbing her in it.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catran stands outside the Black Garnett Chamber, listening to Shadow Weaver muttering. He isn't sure *how* he feels. He wants Adora back, of course he does. But he wants her to come back for *him,* not for Shadow Weaver. He wants... he wants her to respect him. Understand what he can do. It frightens him to think of that, of having her see him as an equal, and he's not sure why that is, either.

Shadow Weaver's chanting and muttering drones on. He wonders, idly, what her actual name is. Shadow Weaver is just a title, it describes what she does, not who she is. She *must* have had an actual name once. Does anyone, anywhere on Etheria, know that name? She was a child at some point, someone must have raised her.

He's so bored. *See that I'm not disturbed.* Like anyone would bother.

She *wanted* him to see that little display. She wanted to scare him with her magic, and she did. Catran has never understood why Shadow Weaver keeps needing to scare him. It's like she's afraid he'll forget that she's this big bad sorceress if she doesn't keep reminding him.

That's an interesting thought, actually. It *is* a little like she's afraid of Catran. Is that why she wants Adora back so badly? Adora has always been Shadow Weaver's obsession, the favored child. Catran used to think that Shadow Weaver loved Adora, but as he's

grown older he's lost that conviction. It isn't clear that Shadow Weaver feels love. Even if she did, everything she says or does is a lie on some level. So if she wants Adora back, she has plans for her.

Is it because Adora can be controlled, and Catran can't? That's another interesting thought. Because it means that Shadow Weaver thinks she might be vulnerable, which means she might actually be vulnerable, and if she has a vulnerability, Catran can find it and exploit it.

Shadow Weaver lies on the floor, unconscious. Catran briefly considers killing her but thinks better of it. It would be hard to explain, for one thing. He knows he's going to have to climb over Shadow Weaver to move up in The Horde, but just gutting her on the floor of the Black Garnett Chamber isn't going to accomplish that.

Not yet, anyway.

For now, he wants to take advantage of the opportunity to look around this place. He notices that there is still a faint glow coming from what looks like a big bowl on a pillar in the middle of the room. This is the bowl that Shadow Weaver conjured her shadow spies from. He approaches cautiously.

In the water, he can see a brightly lit room. The floors are covered in a white and gray patterned stone that he doesn't recognize. He's looking down, and he can see Adora in the room, hurrying towards the dark skinned boy and the purple haired girl, who are sprawled on the floor. He can't see her face but he can see her concern and worry in the set of her shoulders, the way her red jacket is slightly scrunched below her neck. As the scene fades, the two figures begin to stir and he sees some of that tension leave her body.

A bolt of rage strikes from his heart to his stomach and his fists clench. How *dare* she? Who even *are* these people? What do *they*

have that he doesn't?

Nothing. That's what they have. Nothing. And he's going to prove it to her. He's going to bring Adora home and she's going to understand that she was *wrong* , that she should never have left, that no one deserves her like Catran deserves her. That's what she's going to see. Because these people are stupid, and weak, and Catran is smart and strong, and she's going to see that.

"You've been going about this the wrong way, old woman," he tells the unconscious Shadow Weaver. "If you want to take down Adora, you've got to go for the heart."

Chapter End Notes

Short chapter this week. Our protagonist is figuring out that they might be more powerful than they think they are.

Next week we have the Prom.

Eye Contact

Chapter Summary

> Catran has to admit that Scorpia looks objectively devastating in the black dress.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catran has to admit that Scorpia looks objectively devastating in the black dress. He thinks for a moment that Adora will be jealous, seeing him with this ridiculously buff woman, but of course she won't. Apparently, her type is purple, sparkly, poofy haired princesses anyway. He hates that little rat so much. That's okay, though. She's weak. She's going to be easy to take out.

To his surprise, this thought makes him slightly guilty. Catran doesn't understand this at all. He has no problem with violence. He enjoys fighting. He has hurt people, and he doesn't feel any remorse that.

They were all necessary. Isn't it neccessary to hurt this stupid princess? Isn't she the enemy?

She is, of course. But she isn't *his* enemy. Not really. She doesn't know he exists. He'll have to change that, *make* her his enemy. Then it will be okay to fight her. Adora might not like it. She's always tried to make him feel bad for hurting her other friends. Well, she'll just have to get over it. Once he gets her back, he'll have time to figure out how to make her see reason.

Catran still hasn't figured Scorpia out. He knows that she definitely does *not* like boys. He can tell, just by the way her eyes move around in different situations, around different people. Everyone has tells. He knew Adora liked girls before she knew that she cared whether she did or not.

Except that for some reason, Scorpia is always looking at him. Always talking to him, trying to be his friend, trying to get close to him. She *looks* at him funny. She was thrilled to be in his room. She must want *something* from him, but he can't figure out what that could even be.

Whatever. She wants something from him. He can use that.

It's easy to convince Kyle and Lonnie to go along with the plan. He doesn't even have to convince them, he just *tells* them, "We've got a mission." They don't even ask who ordered him to go. Horde training isn't big on independent thought, which is why he's always been able to out think Adora.

Once they arrive, it's surprisingly easy to sneak Kyle and Lonnie in, to overpower the guard at the weapons check, to find uniforms. It's like the Princess who runs this kingdom hasn't even *considered* the possibility that someone will attack during the ball. All of the highest value targets on Etheria are here, in one place, and yet everyone is acting like they're not even in a war.

This just confirms what Catran has always thought. The enemy isn't very strong. Hordak just isn't a very good leader, and Shadow Weaver isn't interested in anything but her stupid rock. He's a little worried about convincing them to provide transport, but it turns out the Scorpia has that covered.

There's no challenge at all in the air as they approach the Kingdom of Snows. Catran can't believe how easy it is to get into the kingdom, into the palace. The dreams that he and Adora had when they were younger, of taking over the Horde, taking over the *planet,* have never seemed so easy to achieve.

Catran escorts Scorpia up the ice covered steps to stand before the throne. The Princess Frosta is trying very hard to look grown up, but she can't hide her discomfort with the situation. Clearly, she would rather be anywhere but here, and she shifts uncomfortably in her thick coat.

And *of course* Adora is going to try to get them kicked out. It's so easy to outmaneuver Adora that it's barely even fun. Adora always has been hopelessly naive and awkward.

Adora also looks objectively devastating. Catran can't look away. Her powerful shoulders are bare in the cold air, and the long red dress can't hide the muscles in her legs. Catran keeps her looking at him all evening, playing cat and mouse games, distracting her from his plan, but his real reward is the animation in her sapphire eyes and the grace of her movement. *And* seeing her looking through the garbage. *That* is priceless. She's such an idiot.

One thing Catran doesn't expect is how uninterested Adora is in the sparkly princess she came with. And Sparkles is shooting dirty looks across the room at the heart boy, who looks ridiculous in a tux that shows his stomach. *We get it, Arrow Boy, you've got abs. Yay for you.* He showed up with the flower kingdom princess, apparently, who is *clearly* checking Scorpia out.

"Are you also observing the social experiment?" The voice is sort of high and overly enthusiastic. What he can only describe as a *tendril* of purple hair snakes towards his plate. He watches in fascination as it splits into multiple smaller tendrils, which wrap themselves around the bits of tiny food he gathered from the buffet and disappear back towards the speaker. She's a short, strongly built woman who is definitely not dressed for this event. She's wearing a welding helmet, for one thing, and her eyes are hidden behind a pair of goggles.

"Absolutely," he replies.

"Are you getting a better view from the balcony? I worry that I'll miss something if I'm too far away."

"Not at all! You can really see the patterns from up here. Check it out!"

The woman walks over to the edge of the balcony on her pigtails and lifts herself effortlessly onto the railing. She leans out. "

Fascinating. "

Adora follows him up onto the balcony and takes the purple haired princess aside. Catran can hear her warning to the woman, who doesn't seem very committed to the rebellion from what he can tell. Information to file for later.

And then it's the first dance, and he manages to be standing next to a partnerless Adora. It's cute, how lost she looks in situations like this. Anything she hasn't planned for is a source of anxiety. He's going to have fun keeping her off balance, while Scorpia, Lonnie, and Kyle kidnap her friends, steal her sword, and ruin her perfect new world. If he can he'll grab her as well, but he really wants her to come to him, begging for mercy.

Which she won't get.

He dips her, challenging her. When she finally breaks and attacks him, he doesn't fight back. Why bother? The security here will take care of her, or at least, she won't be willing to fight them. Poor, naive, rule-following Adora. With her at his side, they could have walked in here and taken this kingdom over in a moment.

Lonnie, Kyle, and Scorpia are jubilant during the ride back to the Fright Zone. They've captured the sparkly poofball princess and her ab-flashing companion. They've seized the sword, which seems to be the source of all the trouble. They left Adora dangling on the side of a cliff, although Catran’s pretty sure she'll get out of *that.*

Catran should be jubilant too, but he isn't. He thinks about what Adora said to him while he was hanging from her hand, dangling a thousand feet over the ground.

"I'll get us out of this."

I'll get *us* out of this.

Adora still doesn't get it. Catran could probably climb that cliff *without* claws. But she still thinks she has to rescue him. Well. She'll think differently now. Now that he's taken her friends and her sword, she'll see that she needs to take him seriously.

But what... *what* was that feeling? What was passing between them when she caught him at the cliff's edge? Why did he just collapse in her arms? What *was* that? It almost felt...

He knows better. He *knows* better. Adora doesn't, *can't* , *won't* ever see him that way. He can't be what she wants, he is what he is. There's no fixing it. Not ever. He has to kill that feeling. He wonders if maybe she was using him. Maybe she knows. Of course she knows. How could she possibly not know how much... how he feels? It's obvious. She can't be *that* clueless.

So she knows, and she was using that moment of closeness. Using it to make him weak. Like she has always tried to make him feel weak. Doesn't she belong to Shadow Weaver? Isn't she the perfect pet? They've been messing with his head his whole life, one kind, one cruel, Catran in the middle, fighting for them, fighting their lackeys, fighting himself.

He's done. He's just done with this stupid game. He has her new friends. He has her new friends and he's going to give them to Shadow Weaver. Maybe she'll give him a break for once when he hands her someone new to torture.

Arrow Boy and Sparkle Girl are still unconscious. Kyle and Lonnie are congratulating each other, again, on their swift capture of the rebel archer. Scorpia moves over to Catra.

"Nice plan, Wildcat," the giant hybrid has a giant grin. "I knew you'd come up with something as soon as you started talking! We make a great team, don't we?"

If the cockpit of this stupid transport were any bigger, Catran would find some way to move away from that ridiculous smile, but

it isn't, so he just scowls. "Yeah, well, they aren't all that smart. I can't believe no one tried this before."

"There hasn't *been* a Prom in a decade!" Scorpia replies. "This was our first chance, and *hoo boy* did we nail it! Thanks to you!"

And here she shoots Catran a... a look. It's all shiny. If he's not careful she's going to try to hug him again.

"Easy, Scorpia," he says. "Let's keep a lid on our enthusiasm until we're back in the Fright Zone."

"Sure, sure." Scorpia instantly looks away, but he can still see her annoying face. There's something... the thing is, Scorpia is huge. Like, twice, three times his size. She's a solid wall of muscle. And something about that is so, well... comforting. He kind of wants the hug, if he's totally honest with himself. It would be nice to be sort of... well, *surrender* to all that energy and strength. It's...

Weak. He tells himself. *This is just another weak part of you. And as soon as she sees that, she'll understand that you're barely worth talking to, much less hugging.*

Whatever Scorpia sees when she looks at me, it isn't me. So whatever weird thing is going on behind that shiny look, it doesn't have anything to do with him. Catran is not going to let *anyone* past his guard, *ever* again.

Chapter End Notes

No, Catran, Scorpia doesn't like boys.

But she does like you.

Think about that.

Invasion Force

Chapter Summary

Catran has Adora's friends.

Will she even bother to save them?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Sometimes that's just the way of things."

Shadow Weaver sounds so disgustingly smug.

The way of things. It *is* the way of things. Catran always ends up with nothing but the scraps. He beat Adora. He brought her stupid glittery princess friend and her sword back to the Fright Zone, it was his plan, his effort, *his* team, and he still is getting shoved aside like he’s nothing. Nothing but an animal that she can send to do her bidding.

Which is all Shadow Weaver will ever see him as. An animal. Less than. Worthless.

He stalks the corridors of the Fright Zone. People have, generally, avoided him. Word like Catran gets around. Now, with a Captain's badge, people *really* avoid him. Even the other Force Captains. *Especially* the other Force Captains, because Octavia has told her own filthy, lying version of how she lost her eye enough times that they think he's a vicious animal too.

Well, he's had to be, hasn't he?

He makes his way to one of his favorite perches, an abandoned landing stage that looks out towards the whispering woods. He feels safe up here. Some places he hangs out can be reached by anyone. This one is just theirs, his and Adora's.

Things have changed between the two of them over the last few years. When he thinks about it, she's been moving further away from him the whole time. Ever since she was officially put in charge of their squad, she's been harder on Catran. More convinced that she knows what's right. What *he's* doing wrong.

Does she even remember? He knows she's never understood. But does she *remember?*

Catran has never been to Adora what she's been to him, he knows that. He's her... pet, essentially. Kyle had a pet mouse when they were younger, he would give it part of his ration bars, so it stayed around the barracks. The constant presence of prey had driven Catran nuts, but Kyle.. well, it was hard to hurt Kyle. He was kicked around almost as much as Catran but couldn't defend himself nearly as well.

Lonnie had built a cage for the mouse, so that other mice wouldn't get its scraps of food. Kyle would take the mouse out of it's cage occasionally, it would run around, even sit in his hand or on his shoulder. The mouse made Kyle happy.

But Kyle was the mouse's whole world. If Kyle didn't bring food, it would die in that cage. If he didn't bring water, it would die. If he stopped caring, it would die. Eventually Kyle had decided to release the mouse back into the Fright Zone. Two days later, Catran had come upon its body, rotting in the dust. It had probably eaten something poisonous. It still smelled faintly of Kyle.

Adora has stopped caring about Catran, and he feels like at any moment, he's going to eat something poisonous. She's always made him weak like that. It was worth it, though, to have just one person he felt like he could count on. One person who he never thought would let him down.

Even when she did. Everytime over the last few years that she's taken Shadow Weaver's side in some argument, every time she's pushed at him to change, to be more of an order taker and less of

a person... he's let it go. Because *he* remembers how they planned to rise to the top, to take over the Fright Zone, to be free of Shadow Weaver and Hordak and finish the war and just be *done* , done with all of this.

He always thought that she was working on the plan. So he forgave her, time and time again. But was she? It sure doesn’t seem like it now. It seems now like she's abandoned him, abandoned her shiny new friend, abandoned everything. Maybe he never really knew her. Maybe he was blinded by his need and by the glow that always seemed to surround her. He was drawn in and fooled by her shine just like everyone else.

He hears the skiff approaching and looks. Well. It looks like maybe Adora hasn't abandoned her friends after all. This should be interesting.

Catran watches.

He watches the purple haired princess and the flower girl disable the lights. He watches as a blue haired princess invades the sewers. It's a pretty good plan, even if it goes a little wrong at the doors as some big dumb guy actually leaps up on a pile of scrap to shout "Forward!". It does act as a bit of a distraction, at least. The two guards are still focused on the idiot when Adora arrives to beat them senseless.

She is so beautiful that it hurts to watch her. She moves like light dancing on water and it takes her less than a second and only three strikes to disarm and disable both men. Catran smiles and makes his way back into the fortress. He wants to see how this all goes. Probably they'll hit the cell blocks first, so he heads that way.

From his perch on a rail at the top level of the cell block, Catran watches the infiltration. The Princesses have taken the control room and it looks like Kyle is talking to Arrow Boy. Probably spilling all the secrets.

If Kyle is here, it's likely Lonnie and Rogelio are around as well. He spots them as Adora and her crew ride a platform up to Arrow Boy's level.

Watching Lonnie and Adora fight isn't nearly as much fun as watching her fighting the guards. Adora clearly is holding back, and Lonnie is so angry that it's making her sloppy. They're both better than they're showing and it makes Catran vaguely sad. Lonnie loved Adora too, just like Catran. That thought makes him a little angry at both of them so he shifts his attention to the control room.

Rogelio has made his way down there. The big lizard crashes through a window and moves to attack the two princesses still inside. It's a little hard to see but there's a struggle going on in there. He assumes Rogelio will lose. The big guy is strong but not particularly fast, and the Princesses have magic powers.

Lonnie makes it back to the platform Adora is riding. Adora is *really* holding back in this fight, she disables two more soldiers without injuring them and almost gently tosses Lonnie onto another platform. A few seconds later, Rogelio hurtles backward out of the control room and lands on Lonnie as her platform drops past. It would be funny if it weren't so pathetic.

Catran could probably stop them at this point, or at least slow them down until enough soldiers showed up to take out Adora, but why bother? Shadow Weaver wanted the credit for this little action, there's no reason for Catran to help her now.

Besides, Arrow Boy isn't important. The *real* prize is Sparkles, and Sparkles is in the Black Garnett Chamber. Catran doesn't think Adora planned for that, and Adora is terrible at improvisation. Still. Kyle undoubtedly told Arrow Boy that that's where Sparkles would be, so that is where Catran goes next.

Seeing Adora with her hands bound should be satisfying. It sort of *is* satisfying. It's especially satisfying when she tells Sparkles that

she's going to save her. Catran doesn't laugh out loud, but he sort of wants to. Adora is captured. She has clearly lost. There's no way for her to escape whatever Shadow Weaver has planned for her, and no way to protect Sparkles from even more torture.

Catran has spent some time testing out the rack that Sparkles is in. It isn't the worst that Shadow Weaver can do, not by a long shot, but it's painful.

He wants to see this. He wants to see the look on Adora's face when she realizes that she failed, that she was wrong to leave The Horde and wrong to leave him, that she is alone. He wants her to break, and he wants to be the one to put her back together.

Somewhere, deep in his heart, he also wants her to win. To somehow defy Shadow Weaver, even in this awful situation, and get away for good. For the first time, he thinks that she doesn't belong here. She isn't ugly and broken like everything else here. She's beautiful and whole and he hates seeing her bound to that table.

He knows that table, too. He knows, or he thinks he knows, every means of torture that Shadow Weaver posseses.

Adora looks at him, angry.

"What have you done to her?" She demands.

He's about to reply when Shadow Weaver enters and places a hand on his shoulder.

"Leave us." She says. The soldiers that brought Adora in quickly file out.

"Report to the Captain's Barracks and pack your things," she tells Catran contemptuously. "Now that Adora is back, there's no need for you there."

"Seriously? After everything I've done for you, it's still *her* you want?" Catran demands furiously. It's unbelievable.

Shadow Weaver grabs his arm and shoves him out of the chamber, shouting, "I said GO!"

Catran stands in the doorway for a moment, and looks back at Adora. She looks... hurt. Not pitying. She's never pitied him. Just... sad. He wonders if Adora would be willing to protect him, now that she has seen through Shadow Weaver's lies.

The door closes, but Catran stays put, listening. Adora offers to stay willingly, if Shadow Weaver will let Glimmer go. Shadow Weaver sounds crazier than usual when she replies. She is planning on erasing Adora's memories.

Catran sucks in a breath. He's seen her do this before. Many times. Every time they get a new group of war orphans they would spend a little time with Shadow Weaver and come out... different. Usually they only forgot the last few days, forgot that they had been captured. Just sort of empty, ready to to take in the Fright Zone's indoctrination. Usually they would be told that the Princesses had destroyed their homes, that the Horde had arrived just too late to save their parents, but that they could have their revenge.

Shadow Weaver made them ready to believe it.

Catran has watched this happen for years. It doesn't always work. He's seen children come out of Shadow Weaver’s presence who can't feed themselves, don't know how to use the bathroom, don't speak. Kyle was like that. He was eight years old and had to learn not to shit himself all over again.

It's always been a fear of his that she would make him forget Adora, or make Adora forget him. If she could be that precise, he's sure she would have done it already. So this... is she going to risk Adora like this? Knowing how it could all go wrong?

She's gloating about it. Even for Shadow Weaver, this is creepy. He wants to go in and stop her. He might be able to get through the door, but he can't move. He can't even extend his claws. He's terrified of Shadow Weaver, of what she'll do to him if he fails to stop her. What if she turns that awful power on him?

While he stands with his head against the door paralyzed with fear, he hears Sparkles scream and scream, and then he hears the chiming sound of her teleporting. The sound of a blow, and something heavy hitting the floor.

She must have taken Shadow Weaver out with one punch. He's impressed, a little.

The door opens, and he hides easily. He watches Adora and Sparkles help each other out of the room, leaning together for support. She's supporting Adora. Like he should have done.

Catran wants to be a part of that. He doesn't care if Adora has found a girlfriend. He just wants to be back with her, feel her scratching his ears, let her pet his mane. He hasn't been touched like that by anyone since she left. Scorpia hugs, too much, but she isn't sensitive to him like Adora was. She doesn't care, not like Adora did. So he goes to retrieve the sword and bring it to them. Maybe if he brings it back, they can all leave together.

He catches up to them at a dead end. They're trapped. He feels angry and defiant as he walks down the hall towards them. He’s in control at this moment. They only escape if he lets them. He trails the point of the sword along the wall, so they’ll know he’s coming.

Adora faces him, afraid but unwilling to show it, ready to fight if she has to.

He offers her the sword.

"What are you doing?" She asks.

"Take it."

She gets the start of her stupid grin and he says quickly, "This is *not* because I like you."

She takes the sword, baffled. "Catran, I..."

He wants to ask her to take him but he *can't.* So instead he says, "Just get out of here." *Take me with you.*

Catran almost lets himself hope that she'll ask him to go. If she wants him to, truly wants him with her, this is the moment to ask. Not when he's angry with her, or trying to take her home, but *now,* when the choice is all hers and he's given her all the power. In front of her shiny new friend. *Please, Adora. Please ask me.*

She doesn't. She holds the sword up, and calls "For the honor of Grayskull." There's a flash of light, and the giant Princess turns and cuts the door in half with one swift strike. Adora is gone. She belongs to She-Ra, now. She-Ra and Sparkles.

Catran leaves quickly, fighting tears.

So *stupid.* So *weak.* So *pathetic.*

He can barely walk. His stomach is full of hot lead and he can't hold the tears back. So he does what he's always done. He hides.

But now there's no one to find him and bring him out of the dark.

Chapter End Notes

> It's interesting how much these two underestimate each other. Catran thinks he's been protecting Adora all these years, but she's never needed it. Adora thinks she's been protecting Catran, but in some ways she's just made things worse.
>
> This is something I noticed about Season One, though. Adora never really tells the others about Catra, about how she wants this other Horde soldier to join the rebellion. And the

one time she could have asked Catra to come with her in front of someone else. she doesn't.

A lot of other fics talk about Adora and Catra being shamed or punished for their relationship, which got me thinking about how Catran might internalize that shame, and believe that Adora must be ashamed of them.

Into the Woods

Chapter Summary

Catran catches Entrapta in the walls of the Fright Zone.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Seeing Shadow Weaver getting hers back is... satifsying, Catran thinks. He feels like he should enjoy it more than he does, but he is definitely enjoying it. Scorpia is correct, unfortunately. It was his plan, and it did fail.

That doesn't feel good.

It could have worked. They could have just let Sparkles go and kept Adora. Or killed Adora and kept Sparkles. Shadow Weaver was the one who had to have Adora back without her memories. *And* she had dismissed Catran, leaving herself alone without support. Those were Shadow Weavers mistakes.

She took a perfectly good plan and ruined it.

Hordak dismisses everyone but Shadow Weaver. In Catran's experience this is never a good sign, unless it's *perfect* Adora being told how *perfect* she is by Shadow Weaver, which has happened plenty.

Hordak hadn't sounded like he wanted to tell Shadow Weaver how perfect she was. *Serves her right.*

"Serves her right," he says to Scorpia. They are walking back towards the Captain's Barracks. Catran is dreading the part where she asks him if he wants to "think about their next move" or "maybe talk about, um, strategy?" He likes talking to Scorpia about strategy, mostly so he can think out loud, but it would be just as useful to to talk to the robot that's been following them

down the hall. The robot wouldn't add its own dumb ideas, at least.

"She wants to take the credit for my plan, she can take the blame, too," he continues. Then stops. The weird robot has put him on the alert, and he thinks he hears a faint sound from the duct that runs along the hallway. He sniffs.

There's a familiar and yet unfamiliar smell. He can't place it, but he knows it isn't a Fright Zone smell.

He shushes Scorpia so he can focus.

He crouches, sniffing, moving his head back and forth to triangulate. Then he reaches and and opens a vent, and the purple-haired Princess he last saw at the All Princess Ball simply tumbles out, looks around.

"Uh... hi!" Her voice is squeaky and uncertain.

Well. Looks like they left someone behind after all.

Catran doesn't have any experience interrogating people, unless he counts subtly trying to figure out if Adora has a crush on anyone. *That* hadn't gained him anything except figuring out that Adora doesn't care for boys and likes her girls with lots of muscles. Since Catran was a boy the last time he checked, and is more compact than bulky, this interrogation hadn't led him anywhere good.

It's weird, though, that Adora has taken up with a pink haired, dumpy, brainless sparkle factory. He wouldn't have thought that the Princess of pretty little lights would be her type. Just one of the many ways in which he never really knew her. That stupid, smiling, idiot.

Since she left, his near constant stomach aches have expanded into his chest and the whole stupid world sucks even worse than it already did.

This is stupid, he thinks. *Focus. You have a problem. Solve it.*

He's always been good at detaching himself from the things he needs to do. Like maiming a couple of boys or vivisecting a mouse, there are things, even terrible things, that have to be done. Getting this Princess to talk is just another one of those things. He's got her shackled to the wall, weird hair and all, and she's been there a while. She should be scared. He's strong. He can face that.

He checks to make sure no one is around, and then uses his Captain's Badge to open a weapons locker and retrieve a shock stick. Technically, he shouldn't be walking around the Fright Zone armed unless he's on guard duty, but with Shadow Weaver stuck in Hordak's chambers there's no one around to care.

He makes his way back to the interogation chamber, stopping to pick up Scorpia along the way.

The interrogation is going weirdly, he has to be honest. The Princess, Entrapta, seems completely oblivious to being threatened. She's just interested in the weapons. Catran isn't sure where her levers might be until she mentions that she is "waiting for her friends to come back."

Typical Adora. Use someone and leave them behind. He can definitely work with that.

An interesting thing about Entrapta is her hands. She never seems to use them to touch anything. She seems to prefer keeping them close to her body. But her hair... her hair is everywhere, touching Scorpia's tail, taking his shock stick, exploring the world around her. It moves with a life of it's own, like it's a separate being.

He reaches out and runs his claws through one pig tail, gently separating the strands. He keeps his eyes on Entrapta while he does this, and she doesn't seem completely aware of the contact. It's soothing, but she isn't really focused on it.

"Some friends." He tells her, continuing to stroke her hair.

He moves closer, keeping his voice low, practically purring.

"All these princesses care about are people just like them. But you're not like them, are you?"

Entrapta notices him touching her hair and takes it back, cuddling the pigtail to her body. The other tail pulls a device out from some pocket and presses a button.

She begins talking.

"Fright Zone log hour 45... is that right? I don't think that's right."

Catran smiles to himself. Whatever this weird princess does, she'll do it for The Horde now. Her weakness is loneliness. He has Scorpia on his side. It's almost unfair.

It's a little disconcerting when she blows up a wall just to show him a bot, but he can work with that too. Besides, her maniacal laughter is kind of infectious.

Catran is annoyed.

Because this is stupid. He's in these stupid woods, following this stupid pad, which is absolutely destroying his instincts and his night vision and he isn't getting anywhere. What even is "First One's Tech"? How is he supposed to recognize it?

He probably should have asked Entrapta more questions, but he was eager to get started, to get ahead of Shadow Weaver. He wanted to get out before Hordak was finished with her. That hadn't worked out at all.

He wonders what Hordak even did to her. Whatever it was, it hurt her, weakened her. It wasn't as satisfying as he would have hoped. His stupid, weak heart just had to feel something for Shadow Weaver, despite everything.

Well. She'll see that he isn't a mediocrity when he returns from these stupid woods, if he even bothers to return from these stupid woods at all. Part of him just wants to get lost here and never come out. The smell is just as intoxicating as it was the last time, so much information on the wind, so many new things. He can identify at least five different animals, and countless plants. The air in the Fright Zone hurts, but here... his stomach feels better. He could get used to this.

If he could just figure out where he's going and this stupid tracker pad would stop fading into static every ten stupid seconds.

He stumbles over a rock that he missed because he was trying to get the pad to work and just gives up, flinging the malfunctioning device into a tree, breaking it.

"I should have know better than to trust a Princess," he mutters.

Two Princesses, now that he thinks of it. Scorpia is a princess too. That means that somewhere under all that stupid shiny happy garbage is something powerful. It's weird to think of Scorpia as powerful, it doesn't fit at all. She's incredibly strong, her pincers can cut through things as well as Catran's claws, but she's *weak.* She follows him around like... like Kyle follows Lonnie and Rojelio. Like a robot.

Horde training sucks. It creates people who can't *do* anything, they can only follow people who can. Like Adora. She never could do anything, just follow orders and instructions and "optimal" battle plans.

Most of the time, anyway. Unless she was really pressed, forced to improvise, forced to be more than a machine.

And why is he thinking about Adora anyway? Catran stumbles again, gets caught up in a vine. These woods just suck.

Then he notices the lights.

They float in the air above him, moving about slowly. He isn't sure why, but they give the impression that they're watching him. That they belong here, and he doesn't. Horde kids were always told to avoid the Whispering Woods, that it was a place soldiers wouldn't return from. He's always assumed that this was garbage, but right now he isn't so sure.

They're just lights, he tells himself. *Lights can't hurt you.*

That isn't even remotely true. A cannon or a shock stick is also "just light" and of course both of them can hurt or kill. This light is magic, and Catran knows how much magic can hurt. He's starting to really hate these woods. He's going to kill Entrapta when he gets back.

And then he notices another, much brighter light, and he spots Adora walking towards it. At the sight of her, something loosens in his chest. How annoying. Why should he feel safe around this magic weilding Princess who doesn't even care about him anymore, if she ever actually did?

Well. Whatever she's doing here, he'd bet a weeks rations that she's looking for the same thing he is. He climbs silently into the trees and follows her. She's walking towards a building, a huge stone tower that is blazing with light. That looks like a place where there might be some tech. And Adora is going to lead him right to it. He chuckles to himself.

"Hey Adora."

Chapter End Notes

I really do think loneliness was Entrapta's weakness. She literally built friends because she didn't have any.

Still... it didn't take much, did it?

Next week is "Promise".

Lies

Chapter Summary

Catran reaches his breaking point.

Chapter Notes

This chapter has a scene with sexual abuse of a child. It isn't graphic, but it is there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Following Adora into the building is easy. She's clearly distracted, and she's never been very good at watching her own back anyway. Catran's always been there for that. Adora probably assumes that bad things just don't happen to her for some magical reason.

He follows her down the corridors. It's all stark and metal. In a strange way, this place reminds him of the Fright Zone, except that instead of glow-bulbs it has weird patterned lights on the walls.

He hears Adora ahead. She's ranting at someone about healing or the sword or something. He can hear the stress in her voice ratcheting up as the whatever it is gives her stupidly rote answers.

He reaches a large, open space. It's brighter in here than in the tunnels, there's a diffuse glow coming from the ceiling that reveals every detail of the room. She-Ra is in the middle of the room arguing with a hologram. Catran has seen training room holograms before, but this one looks sharper and he's seeing it without goggles. So Entrapta is right that this “First One’s” technology is much more advanced than the Horde's.

Adora is so wrapped up in her hologram argument that he can probably grab something and go before she even knows he's here. He looks around. There are pillars around the edges of the

room with the same kinds of patterns on them that he saw on the walls walking in. Looking closer at the nearest one, he sees that there are some kind of crystals embedded in the stone, which look like they may come off.

He's not expecting the entire room to turn red, or expecting Adora to almost vaporize him with a blast from her sword--which apparently is also a *ranged* weapon--or to be running away from giant robot spiders, but he's got the tech and that's what counts.

If he can only get out of this weird place before Adora annoys him to death.

It's so nice to be around her, though. It's so easy to just... not talk. It feels good. He's forgotten how good she smells, even under the fear.

He's never been able to explain smell to Adora, although he's tried. He's not sure if it's just that she's as nose blind as most humans. She hasn't been able to explain certain colors to him either, so he guesses it's the same thing. She smells the world in big overlapping blocks, and he gets the fine distinctions.

One thing that bothers him about this place is that he can't smell the outside world at all. If there's a way out of here, it's through a sealed door. There's no wind. He can hear the sounds of machinery in the distance and the scraping of stone against stone. It's starting to feel like he's trapped inside a living thing, and he does *not* like it.

Then Adora opens a door into a completely dark room, and suddenly, they're in the Fright Zone. Adora turns with her uncanny speed and slams him against a wall, eyes tight and angry.

"What kind of game are you playing?"

What kind of game is *he* playing? Is she even serious? Like Catran could conjure up a vision of the Fright Zone in her stupid castle?

"Woah, woah! I have no idea what's going on. There's no way we can be in the Fright Zone!"

He would have thought that was obvious. She lets him go after some nonsense about Shadow Weaver and he starts exploring. What's odd is that some things are solid, like the wall she slammed him against. Other things, like the sentry, are just holograms. He's impressed with the level of technology. It's almost frightening.

He hears Adora call him and walks over to her. That's when he sees them. Himself. And Adora. Age six. He’s holding his arm where Octavia’s tentacle hit, playing up the pain. She’s come to find him, because she’s been worried about him for months and she’s heard about the fight with Octavia.

His heart hammers in his chest as he fights to keep his breathing steady. He knows this memory, and if he ever figures out who pillaged his mind to find it he's going to tear them into pieces with his bare hands.

Because while Adora shares *this* memory, she doesn’t know what *really* happened. But whoever chose to put them in this place, they must know the whole story, and he feels as violated as he has ever felt.

It started with candy.

Catran is five years old, and alone. He likes being alone sometimes. It is always fun to explore with Adora, but it is more fun when he can show her the new places, and to do that, he has to explore alone first.

He isn't scared. The Fright Zone is home, after all. Sometimes the bigger kids could be mean but Catran is fast and can climb and jump better than them. He can hear better too, so he's hard to surprise. He just has to be careful that Shadow Weaver doesn't

see him. The door in front of him is locked, and he's not sure what's behind it.

He jumps up onto a catwalk and then up to another level, to a hallway that leads in basically the right direction. Most of the Fright Zone is one big building. You can get from just about anywhere to just about anywhere without ever going outside. And a lot of doors are locked, but the funny thing is that if you really know your way around, there might be another way to get behind that door. The Fright Zone is really fun, like one big puzzle.

It also looks like someone fought a battle here. He supposes it was the Princesses, trying to take the Fright Zone and being beaten back by brave Horde soldiers. The hallway he's in isn't leading anywhere interesting so he heads back towards the section he lives in. He can try another route, he thinks there might be a way around by the Captain’s Barracks.

He sees Octavia, resting on a railing about midway between his barracks and the Captain’s Barracks. She sees Catran and waves.

"Hi Catran!"

No one says hi to Catran.

She smiles.

"Hi Octavia," he says cautiously.

"I have something for you," she says. "Something I picked up on my last mission. You and your barracks have been doing so well that I thought you deserved a treat!"

"What is it?" He asks. A treat sounds good.

"It's candy." She says. "It's sweet. Here!"

She keeps her tentacles behind her back as she holds out a hand to him. She's holding a little foil package. He takes it and looks it over.

"Open it!" She says.

It takes him a minute to figure the wrapping out but he eventually does. The thing inside is red, and transparent. It's very pretty and it smells sweet and sort of sharp.

"You eat it," Octavia says. "But not all at once. You have to sort of hold it in your mouth and let it melt."

He tries it. It is the greatest thing he has ever tasted in his entire life. He's never had anything that tastes even remotely like this. It's sweet, but also kind of has a taste at the top of his mouth that he can't identify, and it does in fact sort of melt. It's amazing.

"Listen," Octavia says, "I don't have enough for your whole barracks. So maybe we keep this our secret, okay?"

Catran nods. It doesn't seem like a big deal.

Octavia brings him in slowly. She sees him again about a week later and has another treat for him, which she calls fish. It is salty and delicious and satisfies a craving he didn't even know he had. Two weeks later she tells him that she has treats, but they are in her room, so he follows her. After a few visits, he's sitting on her lap because she wants to pet his mane while he's eating the treats. He doesn't mind that, so much, even though he doesn't really like the way she pets him. He'll put up with a lot for fish.

Then she starts touching him. Not his mane, but the sensitive areas around his ears. His shoulders. He doesn't like that, he hisses at her and gets up to leave. She says "We wouldn't want Shadow Weaver to find out you've been getting extra treats, would we, Catran?"

That freezes him, and he realizes he is in a trap. She's telling him that if he doesn't do what she wants him to do, she'll tell Shadow Weaver what he's been doing. And he cannot imagine how badly Shadow Weaver will hurt him for this, the names she'll call him while she's doing it. He doesn't want that.

So he goes along. At least there's fish or candy in it for him and he learns that he can just sort of not be there. Adora wonders why he doesn't like being scratched anymore. She knows something is wrong so he starts avoiding her. Adora decided they had the same birthday when she turned four, but he spends their sixth birthday mostly alone. She doesn't understand, she's hurt, but he just can't be around her.

She'll be disgusted with him if she finds out.

He's leaving one day, guilty fish taste in his mouth, when Octavia leans down and says "Next time, why don't you bring Ador-" and he swipes his claws across her eye before she can even finish. She slaps him across the body with a tentacle and he goes flying, landing a little awkwardly because she injured his arm with the strike.

It hurts where she hit him, but he rolls into a crouch and faces her, hissing. His vision has narrowed to a tiny tunnel with Octavia in the center. He's never been so angry in his entire life. She charges. She is huge and fast so he leaps directly up, catching hold of a railing and pulling himself onto a catwalk. There's no way she's going to reach him up here.

He looks down at her. She looks up at him. Slowly, his vision starts to clear. He probably can't take her one on one, not if she knows he's coming, but he's hurt her. She has a hand up to cover the eye he scratched, and there is blood running down from behind it.

"You leave Adora alone!"

She flinches. She's afraid of him! This is the first time he's ever seen someone be afraid of him and it feels great. She should be afraid. He can make her hurt. He can make her blind.

"You don't tell me what to do, you little shit," Octavia growls, but her voice has a hint of uncertainty. She's trying to act like she's not afraid, but she's lying. He can smell it.

"I just did, dumb face."

And with that, he leaves. He *is* going to find Adora. He is going to find Adora, and come back, so that Adora will know that Octavia is dangerous and stupid and has a dumb face and that Adora should stay away from her.

So here they are now in this stupid hologram, and he gets to watch what happened next. He sees himself lie to Adora about why he got into a fight with Octavia. He doesn't want her to know what happened. How easy it was for Octavia to get control of him. He and Adora follow their younger selves through the Fright Zone, and then, somehow, they're in the simulation.

He's not just watching himself bring Adora to Octavia, he's there, next to her, feeling what he felt then, seeing what he saw. He sees Adora call Octavia a dumb face, and Octavia chases them, and he feels all the triumph of stupid six year old Catran. It's true though. He did protect Adora. And she had his back. He remembers that he slept in her bed that night, for the first time in months.

When he returns to himself, they're holding hands. Like they did when they were little. Like they haven't in a long time. No one has. He misses that touch so much, but he snatches his hand back like it's being burned. She's already hurt him. Why give her more?

They keep walking, through the weird multicolored corridors. They reach a room with a huge chasm in the middle and a stone pillar collapsed conveniently across it as a perfect bridge. It looks a little too convenient, really, so they're probably still in a hologram. Predictably, Adora is focused on exactly the wrong thing, she's focused on herself, not on the situation, not on the danger they are clearly still in, and not on getting out of here.

"Why did you let me escape after Shadow Weaver captured us?"

"Not this again."

He heads across the bridge, hoping that the fear of a painful death will stop her from talking. It doesn't.

"It's the one thing I can't figure out. You didn't have to do that. You could have gotten caught."

Yeah. He could have. And she didn't see that at the time, didn't care enough to ask him to go with her. Not in front of her precious Sparkles. He's always felt that separation, the exclusion between himself and Adora around other girls. He felt it with Lonnie too. Adora, alone, seemed to forget, but being around other girls just brought it home. *Catran's a boy. He's not one of us* . Put him next to Sparkles, and all Adora can see is what's on the outside.

Adora hops off the bridge too close to the edge. It crumbles under her foot and for a terrifying second Catran is afraid he won't reach her fast enough. He grabs the bridge with one hand and catches her flailing arm in the other. He could sob with relief.

"Did you really think I would let Shadow Weaver erase your memory like that?" He asks.

"I don't know. Probably."

He can't believe she can look at him and say that, while he's holding her a hairsbreadth from almost certainly simulated death. Why would she think that? Does she remember anything? Did she ever even see him at all, or believe they were friends?

Was everything she ever said to him a lie?

"Yeah, well, you never did have too much faith in me."

"Can you blame me?"

Yeah. He can. Unquestionably, he can blame her. After everything he did to protect her, he can definitely blame her.

Catran can't remember a single time he has ever intentionally hurt Adora. Training matches, maybe, but not outside. He's never

attacked her. He's joked with her and teased her but that's always been mutual. They've shared a bed, shared food, shared dreams. And she thinks he'd sell her out to Shadow Weaver.

It's infuriating. He manages a weak chuckle and a "Not really" before turning away. He can't let it go, though. It's like having a chip in a claw, he just has to keep worrying at it until it smooths out or splits.

"It wasn't all bad growing up in the Fright Zone, was it? I mean, you still have some good memories, right?"

"Of course I do! But... it doesn't change the fact that The Horde is evil!"

Her eyes are wide with fervor. She's just so stupidly sincere that he can't stay mad at her. She's always been the one reliable way to get past all his defenses.

"I had no choice," she continues. "I couldn't go back."

He can't face her. Of course she had a choice. She could have come back. She could have asked him to come with her when it mattered, when it wasn't charity.

She nudges him. "Hey. I miss you too."

This is familiar ground and he falls into their dynamic so easily. He protests, pushes her back, they circle, play fighting, like they've done all their lives. It's one of his favorite things.

So naturally, the stupid holograms start up again.

Well. That's interesting.

Oh good. He gets to be fourteen again.

He's in his old body again, this time sparring Adora. He can't hear his old thoughts but he can feel the shock of the staffs

connecting, the pounding of his heart. He loves fighting Adora because she isn't *boring* .

Still he never could resist showing off to her a little bit. He sees the opening, remembers the quick decision, and simply taps her on her big stupid forehead instead of striking. Adora likes sparring with him because *he's* not boring. She gets it. Almost.

He feels his hands tighten instinctively when she intercepts a strike by catching the staff, which is a mistake. She uses that leverage to simply throw him. Even in memory, the impact hurts. He's also still embarrassed at how she tricked him into that. He tricks her back, playing on her soft side. She should have learned by now that the fight isn't over until the buzzer sounds. She needs to learn that.

Maybe that's an excuse.

He's surprised at how much it hurts when Lonnie comes in on Adora's side. She isn't supposed to *do* that, it's not fair and while he isn't stupid enough to think that life is fair or anything she's his teamate too. That should mean something, shouldn't it? Why does everyone always pick Adora?

Despite being almost comically easy to defeat, Lonnie provides enough distraction to give Adora the upper hand, and the fight is over.

Catran's mouth is dry. His claws are fighting to come out when he stalks over to Lonnie.

"What was *that* ? Way to gang up on me!"

Lonnie just lifts her chin and smirks.

"You were fighting dirty," she declares, and her voice is so smug and superior that Catran wants to tear out her tongue. "I was just leveling the field."

He's going to kill her. He's fighting the urge to let her know just exactly how little she understands the odds when Adora's hand touches his shoulder.

And like magic, he feels himself relax. His heart slows. His ears soften and turn towards her. Seen from this perspective, where he's thinking his own thoughts but experiencing the old memory, it's hard to believe how quickly Adora's presence can sooth him. He wonders how many times Adora just *being* there has stopped him from maiming or killing someone.

Isn't that a wonderful thing to realize about himself, though. That maybe he is exactly as awful as Shadow Weaver always says. That he's nothing but a beast. He's worthless. His own team hates him. And the only person who doesn't hate him is walking away to celebrate her win without him, as if it actually counts.

Which of course it does.

Because he's worthless.

He makes his way back to the locker room. The chest target thuds dully on the floor. He should put it in his locker, he'll get in trouble if he doesn't but it's so hard to care about anything. The sink is cold under his hands. His throat burns. He looks up and *that is not his face.*

Except of course it is, because none of this is real.

But the spider that climbs through the mirror and spits a stream of sticky goo around him is definitely real. The determination that turns to fear in Adora's eyes, when she finally can't hold him any longer... that's real.

He screamed for her. And she came. But she couldn't save him. She's never saved him. No one has ever saved him.

The pounding of the spider’s legs reverberates through the hallway as it pulls him towards whatever fresh tormet this stupid place is going to come up with next. The webbing chokes him as

he tries to scream for Adora, but Adora is on the other side of the mirror and can't get through.

Well.

He's not going to be rescued, that's for sure. This place is really starting to piss him off. The webbing is tough, but Catran's claws can tear through sheet metal like paper and he has little trouble ripping the disgusting stuff off him. The spider turns, uncertainly, clacking back and forth, and spits again.

This is the part of being in his body that Catran loves. It's so fast, so strong, so nimble. Walking around, he can feel the wrongness in it, like he's wearing armor under his clothes. When he's fighting, he actually *likes* it. Claws that grip into metal, arms that can rip machinery to shreds, reflexes that never miss. It's glorious.

As it turns out, it's easier than he would have thought to simply rip the thing apart. He leaps off and it sinks to the ground in front of him, smoking from the many holes he's put in it. There's no green glow in it's eyes now. This is the part where he gets to slow down and really find out where its weak points are.

And of course, that's when stupid Adora jumps in and stabs it in the head.

"Catran, wait!"

He can feel the roughness of Adora's callused hands through the fine fur on his forearm. She has a strong grip. No doubt she trains as hard in her new life as she did in her old.

"I'm sorry for leaving," she says, and it sounds like she means it. She looks at him, her eyebrows scrunched up in the middle, for all the world looking like she really cares.

"I just couldn't go back to the Fright Zone, not after I saw what The Horde was really doing." She's openly pleading now, eyes

wide. "You could come with me," She continues, squeezing his forearm. "I know you're not a bad person, Catran. You don't belong with The Horde!"

It isn't so much the look in her eyes that is swaying him. It's her scent, and her touch. Adora doesn't smell like anyone else in the world. He can't explain it, but it's unique, a sort of dry, clean smell to her hair, a faint musk to her skin. And he can smell all her emotions and she is a terrible liar even without that, and she is not lying. She wants him free of The Horde. His ears fold down and he's ready to give in and just go with her. But before he can open his mouth, there's a click and a breeze and suddenly they're back in the Fright Zone.

He's not going to get to go anywhere with Adora. At least not yet.

Well. Whatever is running this stupid garbage heap of a simulation, they can definitely recreate pain with pinpoint accuracy. He remembers this, the first time Shadow Weaver grabbed him with her magic.

Every muscle is locked. His tiny body is spasming as muscles fight each other, straining ligaments and bone. He realizes with horror that his claws are cutting into their sheaths, twitching and stabbing over and over into the sensitive skin.

He doesn't need to see this or feel it. He could repeat what Shadow Weaver says here word for word without prompting. He tries to tune it out but the pain is too much and he can't ignore that voice any more than he can order his heart to stop beating.

Which, if he could, right now, he would.

"I've kept you around this long because Adora was fond of you."

Shadow Weaver practically spits the words. He can smell the rot and sickness of her behind that awful mask as she continues, "But

if you ever do anything to jeopardize her future, I will dispose of you myself. Do you understand?"

No. Catran doesn't understand. He's never understood what he did to deserve this, why it's always him, never Adora. They came in here together. They're always together. Five year old Catran doesn't even know what "jeopardize" *means* yet.

But he understands the threat. He understands that she'll kill him if he ever does this thing that he doesn't even know what it is. He understands the pain. He understands the message. *You are worthless. You only matter because Adora is willing to tolerate you. You are nothing without her.*

Yeah. He gets that.

He remembers the relief that he felt when Adora stepped in, begged Shadow Weaver to stop. He doesn't feel it now. It's nice that the pain goes away but honestly, she's done so much worse to him so often that the physical sensation is barely worth noting.

Adora's hand is on his shoulder when they go back to being themselves and he flings it away angrily. Why does she always get to play the hero without ever risking anything? Did she ever even try to make Shadow Weaver stop?

He remembers all the times she asked *him* to try to be a better cadet so that Shadow Weaver would stop hurting him. Like it mattered what he did, when it was so clear that Shadow Weaver was hurting him just for being him. Shadow Weaver hurt him for not being Adora. For not being blonde and beautiful and *special.* For being covered in fur and having claws and not being what she wanted to see.

For being, at his core, worthless.

It's easy to be mad at Adora now.

"You always have to play the hero, don't you?" He demands.

"I was only trying to protect you!"

That's garbage. She never risked anything for him. Not like he did for her.

"You never protected me! Not in any way that would put you on Shadow Weaver's bad side!"

This is tearing him apart. He's saying things that maybe he won't be able to take back, things that are true but only half true and would make so much more sense if they were talking about them late at night, curled up on Adora's bed, where he was safe. Where things were different, where he could feel, even for a moment, that the armor wasn't there, that it didn't define him.

But that's a lie. He's trapped in it. So he says the only thing that he thinks might make it all stop, which is absolutely true, but not the way he says it.

"I didn't want you to come back, Adora!"

And she lets him go.

Because Adora is too dumb to understand that he wanted to go with her. He always has. Even though she's never seen him as worth protecting, maybe never really seen him at all, she's the only real kindness he's ever known.

But she is *such* an idiot.

Catran runs through the flickering holograms, desperate. He just wants to leave at this point. He stumbles and kneels on the floor, gasping.

And he's back in their barracks.

There are no spiders, no threats. Just himself as a kitten and the first of many broken promises.

"It doesn't matter what they do to us," four year old Adora tells him. "You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other."

"You promise?"

"I promise."

Well. Bad things happened. Really bad things. Just not to Adora.

And that's when Catran gets it.

Whoever or whatever is running this trash factory, it wants Adora and it isn't letting Catran go unless it gets Adora. It is screwing with his head as badly as Shadow Weaver ever did, for the same reason Shadow Weaver always did. Catran is just something in the way, like he always is, something between these powerful forces and the person they really want.

Well.

Catran is over this garbage. He's always protected Adora, she's never protected him. He's kept his part of that bargain. He's looked out for her. What did she do? She let Shadow Weaver torture him, over and over again. She let Lonnie bully him. She stopped him from protecting himself. She was part of every plan to tear him down.

He wonders why. Why does Shadow Weaver hate him? Why does this new machine want Adora? Why does everyone choose Adora?

Because they're afraid of him. Catran is faster, stronger, and smarter than Adora. There isn't a soldier in The Horde to match him. Adora is a cage they put around him, a way to control him. She's always tried to control him, to keep him beneath her. Her little kitten, always there, always at the foot of her bed, always so eager to get whatever scraps of attention she can be bothered to give.

Well. He doesn't have to be that anymore, does he? He can get out of that cage. He can make them all suffer for what they've done to him.

And that starts with giving this stupid building its stupid Princess so he can go home. He hears Adora yelling nearby and walks towards her. There are five spiders in the room. Three are crouched by a cliff, where Adora probably is. Two are by the door. He attacks them, starts tearing them apart, but they don't fight him. They simply go dead.

The other three just leave. They pass him without seeming to notice him at all.

He sees the sword at the edge of the cliff, sees the taught lines of spider goo. She's down there, holding on. He hears her gasp.

"Catran?"

She sounds so stupidly hopeful. Like of course he'll rescue her, of course he'll follow her, of course he'll feed on the leftovers of her love. So easy for her. So easy to assume that he belongs to her.

It's all so obvious now. Adora is just as afraid of him as everybody else, hates him just like everybody else. But she's a liar, and she's always been a liar, and she's been pretending to be his friend to keep him below her. She would never have even survived the Fright Zone without him, and he sees now what a mistake it was to protect her. He should have let Octavia have her. Should have let everybody who ever wanted to hurt her have her. Should never have taken punishment after punishment to spare her.

Because she's been laughing at him this entire time. Laughing about how stupid he is, laughing about how easy it's been to manipulate him and hurt him. She was probably in on all of it. Her and Shadow Weaver, cooking up ways to make him weak.

Well.

Catran is done. This garbage ends right now. Maybe Adora ends. Maybe not. He's done caring about her.

He picks up the sword and walks to the edge of the cliff.

"Hey Adora."

Catran wakes. He's in an unfamiliar room, lying on what feels like smooth rock. To the side of him, Adora lies on a crystal platform, bathed in a purple glow from crystals around her head. Tears run from the corners of her eyes. The sword is next to her. He remembers the despair in her eyes as he walked away from the cliff's edge, leaving her to whatever fate she could wrangle. He should feel something about that, but he doesn't.

He tries to summon the hate he was feeling, just moments ago. It isn't there. There's nothing there. No love, no hate. Nothing. He looks at a face that he knows better than anything else in the whole world, and the curve of her lips, her slightly upturned nose, the clean lines of her jaw. He saw that face become what it is, day after day. It's been a constant in his life.

And now it isn't. It's just that simple.

He looks away from Adora and around the room. It's huge, and dark. There are faintly glowing crystals everywhere, marking the dome of the ceiling, farther away than he could jump. As he looks, a blue glow appears in the wall, outlining a doorway. He can see the hallway beyond. It's clear of spiders.

"Yeah, I get it," he tells the empty room. "I'm leaving already."

His backpack is where he left it in the woods. He follows his own backtrail easily enough, he can smell his own fear in the air, and finds the tracker pad. It's functioning perfectly. The way back to the Fright Zone is clear. The woods are quiet for now.

Before he leaves the Whispering Wood, he stops and takes one last breath, tasting every scent. Animals, plants... he can smell

two or three different kinds of trees and those are just the ones he recognizes. His ears twitch at the sounds of life all around him.

He could stay here. He could climb up into one of these trees and just sleep there. He's so tired. He could be done, truly done, with all of it.

A warm breeze flows past him, bringing even more scents. Flowers. Prey. Some kind of plant that seems to jump right into his brain and pull him towards it. He could stay here. He could just be *Catran* here, with nobody watching, nobody telling him what he should be or what he isn't. No one to look the armor into existence.

The woods will take care of him, if he lets them.

"I don't need to be taken care of," he says decisively. "I won't be weak."

The breeze shifts, and he follows the toxic smell back home.

Chapter End Notes

That was a long one.

The scene where Adora asks Catra "Can you blame me?" has always struck me as just emblematic of how much of Shadow Weaver's attitude Adora has internalized over the years. Which makes sense, we're programmed to trust our parents, we learn how to see the world from them.

Stormfront

Chapter Summary

> Catran returns with the First One's Tech Entrapta needs to build an ultimate weapon.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Despite himself, Catran really likes Entrapta.

Partly, it's the laugh. He loves the laugh. It's loud and fearless, *free* in a way that is unusual in the Fright Zone. Scorpia's laugh is nervous, she always seems to be just a little afraid and uncertain. Adora...

Well. He isn't going to think about Adora. Not right now.

Entrapta's laugh is just... he doesn't really have the word. The closest he can get is free, or maybe crazy, or maybe both. It's great.

Then there's the way she treats him. Entrapta just accepts him. She treats him exactly the same way she treats Scorpia. She has a strong sense of personal space, but she allows him in it and it doesn't feel weird. Entrapta isn't suspicious of his motives. She probably should be, but she isn't.

Then there's her hair. Catran is fascinated by the hair. He's always believed that all Princesses are magic, that's what they taught him, but then there's Scorpia and Entrapta. Scorpia doesn't appear to have any magic at all. Entrapta's magic seems to be completely embedded in her hair and she isn't even aware of it. The hair is part of her, and it isn't, it does her bidding but it seems to almost be aware at times.

It is--to borrow a word from Entrapta--fascinating.

Then there's how straightforward she is. She has things she wants, and she's perfectly willing to go take them, and he has things he wants, and she's perfectly willing to help him take them. Entrapta wouldn't tell him he wasn't a bad person because Entrapta doesn't seem to even have the idea that some people are good and some people are bad. She doesn't make him feel guilty.

Which is a feeling he needs right now. So he's pretty relieved when she drops a note on his head from the air vent in his room. He needs an excuse to get out of here.

The note just says *Come to my lab.*

When did she get a lab? What even *is* a lab?

Entrapta's lab is just the room they were holding her prisoner in, now full of equipment. Which she stole.

Of course.

Catran has no idea what she's talking about, really. Runestones, hacking the planet, it's all just words. The thing that comes through is that Entrapta thinks she can control the magic.

Which would control Adora.

Actually, it would control the monster that Adora has become. That's the real problem. The magic. Magic is always the problem. Shadow Weaver's magic, the Sword's magic, whatever magic or tech got into his head back in the First One's building.

Because maybe all this isn't Adora's fault. If the tech and magic got into his head, messed with his thoughts, maybe it's controlling her. Making her leave. Making her his enemy. Maybe this "hacking the planet' thing will break all of that. When he beats her, shows her that she can't win, she'll have to come back.

And maybe he'll want her back, and maybe he won't.

Besides, he can't imagine anything that would make Shadow Weaver angrier than messing with her precious rock.

It's time to let Hordak in on her purple-haired secret.

Catran watches Entrapta connecting wires from different machines to the Black Garnett. It's weird, the idea that someone else could tap into the source of Shadow Weaver's power. It makes sense. It's just a fuel source, a battery. Anyone can use a battery if they know how, and Entrapta seems to know what she's doing.

It was weird, though, how easy it was to convince Hordak to let them try this. He had listened as Catran explained how the Princess had defected, how she had increased the power of weapons, and he had barely started trying to explain about the Black Garnett when Hordak had interupted her.

"And what is it that you have come to ask for?"

"Well," Catran had replied carefully, "She wants access to the Black Garnett."

"Very well.' Hordak had dismissed her with a gesture, but added as she left the throne room, "Be sure I do not regret this decision, Force Captain."

And that was it. Here they were. It was almost laughably easy.

Still. Hordak was watching.

"All right, hurry it up." Entrapta is so engrossed in her work that she probably doesn't even hear him. "Those machines aren't going to hook up themselves."

"They won't be hooked up at all."

Well. Shadow Weaver had to show up eventually.

This is going to be *fun.*

Shadow Weaver is in a cell, her power gone.

The Whispering Woods are crumbling with the cold that is pouring out from the Black Garnett.

It's time to strike, now, while the opponents are confused and frightened. Before they have time to gather their strength and prepare. Bright Moon is there for the taking. That's strategy.

He's going to win. And there is nothing that Adora can do to stop him.

They've always underestimated him. Shadow Weaver, Hordak Lonnie, Kyle, Adora... everyone. They've never understood what he was capable of.

Well. They're going to have to learn the hard way.

Chapter End Notes

> Almost at the end of Book One here. I do have a bit of Book Two written, but it's been slow going lately.
>
> Thanks for coming this far!

Drawing Blood

Chapter Summary

Catran mounts his assault on Bright Moon

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catran stands in front of a room full of Horde Soldiers.

"They have three heavy hitters. Angella, Glimmer, and Adora. Glimmer is the weakest, Scorpia, you take her."

"Sure, okay."

"We haven't seen Angella fight. She'll probably be at the back. Entrapta, I want robots focusing on her."

"No problem!"

"Adora's mine. If she gets past me, attack her in a group. Look to restrain her or distract her, frontal assault won't work. You have to keep her off balance, attack structures or non-combatants to distract her. Got it?"

"Yes, Force Captain."

"Let's finish this."

They move out through the frozen wood. Trees simply shatter as they move towards Bright Moon. Soldiers laugh and punch each other's shoulders. They've been terrified of these woods forever. No longer.

Bright Moon is going to fall.

The plan was to simply overwhelm Bright Moon's defenses with the first wave of mobile infantry, then bring in the tanks and foot soldiers for mop up work. That didn't work, but Catran planned for that. The tanks can destroy the castle, and the real prize is Angella. If she goes down, the Moonstone goes down, and if the Moonstone goes down, Etheria falls.

The entire war can be won in this battle.

Adora, predictably, is in the front lines, trying to fight tanks with brute strength. Well, She-Ra is fighting tanks with brute strength. He'd like to think Adora is smarter than that, but maybe he's just been so blinded by her that he's never seen how truly stupid she is. As if courage and the right cause are all she needs.

If he can draw her away from the battle, though, she won't even matter.

He sees her fighting, brings his tank in. She sees him, takes a shot, falls. He could probably just shoot her again now, but that wouldn't be any fun.

Catran wants to get his claws into her. If he can just rip She-Ra away, tear this false skin off, maybe he can get everything back. Maybe Adora is still under there, the real Adora, not this improbably strong imposter who hates him.

He climbs out of the tank and looks down at her. She's struggling to stand, wobbling from the tank blast.

"Hey Adora."

Well. That could have gone better.

It isn't so much that he lost. Catran is used to losing. He's always losing something.

It's the stupid rainbow. It's She-Ra. He came into a battle with tanks, guns, energy whips, shock rods, magical weather and a

superior plan and he got beaten back by a stupid *rainbow*.

He thinks back to Adora asking him to come with her. To join her and her friends, to be some pathetic sidekick like Arrow Boy, powerless and weak next to the Princesses and all of their magic.

Adora used to understand, back when she was like him. She used to know what it was like to fear magic. She used to know why he didn't like it. Now she has some, has that power and she's forgotten why it's *wrong*. It's She-Ra. He has to separate Adora from She-Ra.

He leaves the interview with Hordak and stalks back to his room, leaving Entrapta and Scorpia to do whatever stupid Super Pal bonding they want to do. He's in charge now. Shadow Weaver is defeated. He can make a new plan. The rebellion is still playing defense and they can't do that forever. He is going to win.

Catran repeats this to himself over and over. *I am going to win. I am going to win. I am GOING TO WIN.*

He walks over to the bathroom, muttering his mantra under his breath. "I am going to win. I am going... to... win." The words are growl.

He stares at the face in the mirror, mismatched eyes looking back, desperate and alone. It's never the face he's expecting, somehow. He's not sure what's wrong with it but it's like the Catran in the mirror isn't the Catran in his head. He hates that feeling.

He thinks about Shadow Weaver in her cell, and smiles. It felt good to beat her. It feels good to know she won't come through the door, can't spy on him in the Shadows any longer.

He undresses and grabs a rough cloth to begin cleaning himself off from the battle. He's glad he's not so young that he can be forced to shower to anymore. That was awful. Not so much the water but the cold of being soaking wet and just unable to dry himself.

Showers. That's when he first realized that he and Adora were different, under their clothes. Not just the fur, he knew that, obviously, but other stuff. It hadn't bothered him much at the time but over the last few years he's noticed it more and more. He wants to be close to Adora or even Lonnie in a way that just doesn't seem possible. Like they're sharing something that he needs to have but can't reach.

Like, what Kyle has with Rogelio, or any number of team members have with each other. The boys he's seen who belong together, in a way he doesn't belong with them. He thinks about it. He kind of gets that feeling, with Entrapta and Scorpia. There's an ease with them, physically, especially with Entrapta. She doesn't want anything from him but doesn't shy away from him.

It's nice. Maybe it's even friendship.

It's still the Fright Zone. He finishes his grooming and pulls on fresh clothes. He puts his mask on, stares at the mirror.

"We're going to win," he tells the warrior staring back at him. "In the end."

Chapter End Notes

So that's the end of Book One. I'm in progress on Book Two.

Thanks to everyone who liked or sent Kudos.

End Notes

Should publish on Friday/Saturday.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!